

LS-003 / FOR TEACHERS & PRACTITIONERS

Getting Started with Literary Science

A practical guide for teachers who want to use literature as operational technology in their classrooms. No certification required. Start this week.

THE CORE IDEA

Literature is technology.

Not metaphorically. Functionally. Technology is something engineered to do something: to solve problems, to transmit knowledge, to enable survival. Literature from marginalized communities has always done this work. It renders designed systems visible. It encodes operational intelligence for community survival and repair.

Literary Science is a methodology that takes what writers have seen and puts it to work. Students do not study the novel. They use it. They extract hypotheses about power, community, and intervention from the text, then test those hypotheses against real data in the communities they come from.

The project that emerges is not inspired by the book. It is built from it.

THE FRAMEWORK

Four sequential movements.

Each movement builds on the one before it. The sequence matters because it prevents jumping to solutions before understanding systems. You cannot do Strategic Response without Flow Analysis. You cannot do Flow Analysis without Asset Mapping.

01 ASSET MAPPING

Who has what?

Before diagnosing what is missing, map what exists. Resources, relationships, knowledge, institutional access. In the novel and in the community.

02 FLOW ANALYSIS

How do things move?

Assets are not the problem. The problem is how they move. Track how information, trust, and capital circulate or get stuck.

03 STRATEGIC RESPONSE

What do you do with what you see?

Convert understanding into action. What would actually change the dynamics? Not what sounds good. What would work.

04 CREATIVE RESTORATION

How do you rebuild?

Design something new. Not a patch on the existing system but a restoration of what should have been there. Rooted in community assets.

Try this in your classroom this week.

You do not need to overhaul your curriculum. Start with one class session. Pick a novel your students are already reading and run them through Asset Mapping. That single movement will change how they read.

STEP 1: CHOOSE YOUR TEXT

Pick a novel your students are already reading, or select one that renders a system visible. The strongest Literary Science novels are by Black and POC authors, show how power and resources move through a community, and contain characters navigating those systems. If you need recommendations, visit literaryscience.com/toolkit.

STEP 2: RUN ASSET MAPPING (45 MIN)

Give students this prompt: "List every asset this character has. Not just money. Social networks. Knowledge. Cultural practices. Institutional access. Skills. Relationships." Let them work in pairs. Then ask: "Now list every asset in YOUR community using the same categories." Put both lists on the board. The conversation that follows will be the best discussion you have had all year.

STEP 3: ADD FLOW ANALYSIS (NEXT CLASS)

Return to the novel. Ask: "Pick one asset from your list. Trace how it moves. Who has access to it? Who does not? What controls the flow?" Then pivot to community: "Find one piece of real data that shows the same pattern." This is where English meets Math. The novel surfaces the pattern. The data confirms or complicates it.

STEP 4: MOVE TOWARD RESPONSE

Once students can map assets and trace flows, the question becomes operational: "Given what you see, what would you do?" Push them past wishful thinking. Force specificity. What exactly would they build, change, or create? Who would it serve? How would they know it worked? This is Strategic Response.

STEP 5: LET THEM BUILD

Creative Restoration is where students design something real. A program, a product, a partnership, a policy recommendation. Make it specific. Make it budgetable. Make it testable. The intervention is their homage to the author whose novel served as operational technology.

PRINCIPLES TO HOLD

What makes this different.

THE NOVEL IS NOT STUDIED. IT IS USED.

If students are writing book reports, something has gone wrong. The novel is operational technology. Students extract hypotheses from it, test them against data, and build interventions from what they find.

THE SEQUENCE MATTERS.

You cannot skip Asset Mapping and jump to Strategic Response. The movements are sequential and cumulative. Each builds on the one before it. This is what prevents the common educational trap of jumping to solutions before understanding systems.

STUDENTS LEAD, NOT PARTICIPATE.

In Literary Science, students are builders. They make real decisions, manage real resources, and serve real communities. The methodology only works if students are operating, not observing.

LITERATURE FROM MARGINALIZED COMMUNITIES IS THE FOUNDATION.

This is not decorative. Black literature has always been encoding operational intelligence for community survival and repair. Literary Science is a methodology for extracting and deploying that intelligence. Novel selection should center Black and POC authors.

START WHERE YOU ARE.

You do not need permission, certification, or a complete curriculum overhaul. You need a good novel and the willingness to ask: "What systems does this text render visible, and what would it look like to build something in response?"

GO DEEPER

Next steps.

Read the full methodology

literaryscience.com/epistemology

Download the Hypothesis Document template

literaryscience.com/toolkit

Explore the Studio for musings and connections

literaryscience.com/studio

Bring Literary Science to your school or organization

literaryscience.com/workshops

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